



1 New Delhi-based bar Khi Khi introduced a chamomile and gin cocktail for a promotional menu

2 Olterra in Kolkata uses tea from the Makaibari Tea Estate in a cocktail

rose petals, vetiver, lemongrass, Himalayan tulsi, and cardamom. The Raffles Chai-Tini mixes this blend with gin to offer a refreshing drink.

It's no secret that Indians love their chai. So, is it only natural that it has found its way into cocktails? "I think

our eternal love for chai actually caused a delay in our understanding of tea in general. The overboiled swirl of a concoction made with tea dust and milk that we call chai was so ubiquitous that we didn't explore this delicate plant for all that it could offer for the longest time," says Buland Shukla, Founder of For the Record (FTR), a cocktail bar in Panjim, Goa. FTR serves a cocktail called Silver Tips, made with white tea, smoked lemons, pineapple, and vodka. Shukla feels that easy access to so many different varieties and processes has opened a whole Pandora's box of flavour development for mixologists.

Take, for example, Lady in Charge, a cocktail served at the InterContinental Marine Drive in

the variety of tea being used to the amount you use to the time taken to infuse or brew, there are so many variables. That's where it becomes tricky; one needs to know his or her tea so that it can be effectively incorporated into a cocktail. An Assam versus a Darjeeling in the same cocktail will give completely different results." For a promotional menu, he introduced a chamomile and gin cocktail called Tea Punch.

New Delhi's Sidecar, an artisanal cocktail bar that secured the 26th spot on the World's 50 Best Bars 2022 list, serves a cocktail called Tea Leaf, which is a take on the classic cocktail Penicillin. It is made with smoked pinewood tea from Anandini and Jim Beam White. "The smoked pinewood tea brings the

TEA WAS COMMONLY USED AS AN INGREDIENT IN PUNCHES AND OTHER MIXED DRINKS IN THE 18-19TH CENTURIES

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Mumbai. This slow-sipping cocktail, made with jasmine green tea and gin, is popular with women who eat lunch at the L&S Bistro there.

Mixologists also have to understand the flavour profiles of different teas to determine what works best with a particular alcohol. "When we went to the Makaibari Tea Estate in Darjeeling, we found that the Autumn Flush blend of that season was the best choice for us, as it could perfectly match the flavours of gin," says Subhobrata Majumder, Bar Manager of Olterra. This Kolkata-based bar's cocktail menu showcases distinct ingredients from various parts of Bengal.

Agrees chef-entrepreneur Tarun Sibal, Co-founder of New Delhi-based cocktail bar Khi Khi: "Tea is a very versatile ingredient. From

whole drink together, just like the peaty Islay scotch that rounds off a classic Penicillin," says Minakshi Singh, Co-founder of Sidecar. "We Indians love our tea, and to harness that love and transform it into a cocktail is a no-brainer. Tea has always been an intrinsic part of who we are and how we create our menus. It's about showcasing various flavours of India," she adds.

Banking on the same love, the Lalit Group of Hotels has recently launched a cocktail called Kadak Chai, which is a mix of vodka and masala chai, at its Indian restaurant Baluchi across all its hotels.

Little wonder; after all, chai fuels the largest population in India, and who says it can't be spiked? **BT**

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